

Less Than DIVINE

The confusion in the Congress over Antulay's controversial remarks show that the party has slipped back to its petty votebank politics after making the right noises post-Mumbai

By Priya Sahgal

To err is human". With those four words, Prime Minister Manmohan Singh sought to put the lid on the controversy kicked off by Union Minority Affairs Minister A.R. Antulay that not only embarrassed the Government but also cast a shadow on its carefully constructed tough facade on terror. By taking no action against the minister, the prime minister seems to have acquired a divine aura by default. While Antulay swaggers around claiming that he sees no need to apologise, it is the Congress that is left red-faced. Post-Mumbai, the UPA had walked into Parliament talking tough on terror. The same Congress that had argued against an anti-terror law did a quick U-turn and brought in a stringent provision of its own. The anti-terror law, along with plans of setting up a federal agency, sent a reassuring message that some of the lessons of Mumbai had been well learnt.

Until Antulay stepped into the picture and demanded a separate investigation into the deaths of former ATS chief Hemant Karkare and two other officers, who were killed while travelling in the same car. He hinted at a Hindu terror conspiracy since the ATS chief had been investigating the role of the Hindu leader, Sadhvi Pragya Singh Thakur, in the Malegaon blasts. "Whether he (Karkare) was a victim of terrorism or terrorism plus something, I do not know.... He found that there are non-Muslims involved in acts of terrorism in some cases. Any person going to the roots of terrorism has always been the target," said Antulay. Overnight, an India vs

Pakistan issue turned into a Hindu vs Muslim finger-pointing exercise.

As Congress spokesmen distanced themselves and others took sides, both Sonia Gandhi and Rahul added to the confusion by keeping a studied silence. Rahul told reporters that "other senior leaders in the Congress will discuss this". It was left to Union External Affairs Minister Pranab Mukherjee to handle the belligerent BJP and confused allies. Moreover, the confusion was allowed to fester for nearly a week until Home Minister P. Chidambaram stepped in with a five-page clarification. He walked a political tightrope and included the BJP in his condemnation, saying that questioning both the investigations conducted by Karkare and the circumstances of his death were "wrong and deeply regrettable". An unabashed Antulay then did a quick climbdown and said he was satisfied with the explanation offered by the home minister. Let alone offering his resignation for stirring up such a sensitive communal cauldron, Antulay saw no need to apologise either.

Clearly Antulay's party is in a mood to understand instead of reprimanding him. There is only one explanation for Antulay's swagger: the charade could not have been possible without approval of senior leaders. He found support from Muslims in other parties and also from non-Muslims within the Congress. "There should be a comprehensive inquiry," agreed Congress MP Sandeep Dikshit while party general secretary Digvijay Singh said, "What is wrong if he asks for a probe?" Digvijay's comments are significant because he is known for his proximity to Congress

